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Mexico

A Brief History

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candidates sought the support of the government, but the candidate of the new Democratic Party was the winner. The party proceeded to organize Democratic Clubs in agricultural areas and town centers, in collaboration with *hacendados* and merchants who had long been excluded from the spoils under Cañedo. In 1909, gubernatorial elections divided the elite coalition in Yucatán and Coahuila. In Yucatán, the struggle began among powerful Porfirian factions, but José María Pino Suárez, running on an anti-re-electionist platform, won in the end. In Coahuila, there were two candidates. Venustiano Carranza was sympathetic to Reyes but was a longtime constitutionalist and carried a lot of weight in state politics. He faced the favorite of the three most powerful groups in the state, Francisco I. Madero. Coahuila became the bastion of liberal constitutionalism as Madero and Carranza joined forces, attracting the popular support to elect Carranza governor.

The gradual splintering of the old system encouraged the Reyes movement, which returned to the political fray and met with some success. In 1909, a Reyista club launched the joint candidacy of Díaz for president and Reyes for vice president. This was a clever move that attracted public support, but ensuing Reyista demonstrations were repressed by the government and a section of the group broke away to join the broad anti-re-electionist coalition.

Factional strife among government forces noticeably weakened the regime in 1908–1909, but they attempted to regroup themselves into a re-electionist coalition. The Porfirian elite was faced with the spread of popular movements, however, to which their own disunity had contributed. As the 1910 presidential election drew near, there was no power vacuum, no opening for any factional takeover. Instead, Mexican society and its political organizations became polarized in terms of two positions on the presidency: re-electionist and anti-re-electionist.

CHAPTER 9

The Revolution

The traditional interpretation of the Mexican revolution tends to describe it as an unprecedented social and political phenomenon having only tenuous continuity with the republican and liberal nineteenth century. Recent historiography, however, puts more emphasis on its nineteenth-century roots and on the role played by the ideas, social groups, and organizations of that century's last decade. These studies also question the monolithic view of the revolution. They endeavor instead to recapture its pluralistic nature and its specific characteristics in different states and regions.

For these reasons, it is useful to remember what was said in the previous chapter about the incongruence at the end of the century between an evident social dynamism and the ossified politics, which were inadequate to the needs of the new social actors who were recognizable some fifteen years before the revolutionary convulsion. More concretely, liberal republicanism retreated in the 1890s as the regime it had spawned proved incapable of regeneration and unable to develop policies that could give voice to the new forms of liberal opposition. At this stage we can begin to discern a growing plurality of social actors in Mexico, the precondition for what today we call the revolution. The new society of the day, born under the republic in the most robust period of liberalism, found its way through a thicket of difficulties to establish new social networks and to transform underlying organizational forms, responding to new demands and extending itself throughout the country.

In this chapter we will examine the efforts of thousands of social ac-

tors to coordinate their own demands and wherever possible to piggy-back them onto the demands of the local and national elites. We will begin by discussing how the 1910 Revolution was born from the entrails of the Porfiriato, and how the revolution's social actors, the citizenry, arrived at new demands, organized them within the framework of preexisting ones, and established priorities.

The Mexican revolution was not, in this view, just a large pluralist popular movement. It was also a confluence of regionally based movements sustained by a strong federalist tradition that never lost control of its territories.

The Social Question

The large-scale social question that drove the movement toward revolution was more than a simple peasant demand for land; it incorporated the new citizen demand throughout the Western world for social and political rights, such as the right for assistance in the case of sickness or accident, the right to universal suffrage, to social peace, to have work and to be paid fairly. However, the situation has not always been understood in these terms. One often-repeated and reductionist interpretation goes like this: The social question behind the revolution has its roots in the agrarian question—the instability of the *pueblos'* traditional properties and the lack of guarantees for small property in general. These conditions, along with threats to property rights by political bosses and state authorities, provoked rural protest between 1890 and 1910. There is truth to this argument, yet these factors cannot be considered in isolation from political demands for free elections, tax justice, definitive land titling, and strict enforcement of the 1877 Constitution. These demands were already contributing to the development of the social question in the decade of the 1890s.

Nonetheless, the traditional land-question explanation of things does have its value. Migrants to new rural, urban, and mining population centers brought rural social problems with them as the demands of day laborers, sharecroppers, and owners of small land holdings were superimposed on the uncertainty over property rights and concrete political rights. In fact these demands were even more visible in the new population centers, lacking as they did the political status of municipalities. The states' refusal to give political recognition to new settlements crystallized the migrants' situation and linked their new problems to those they had faced in their old *pueblos*.

There is not sufficient historical evidence to determine the extent to which prior demands directly influenced events in the new population centers. There were continuities in social organization, however. Migration was not an individual phenomenon. Families and other groups left their *pueblos* together or separately and reproduced their organizational forms in new towns. They established *cofrades* and celebrated their *pueblos'* festival days. In the new settings, the *cofrades* and other traditional groups worked to strengthen community spirit, and they practiced solidarity through mutual aid.

We have more evidence for events in the year 1902, from which we know that new demands had permeated the traditional organizations. There were demands for land rights, voting rights, equal justice, municipal autonomy, the just remuneration of labor, education and training, productive business and agricultural policies, freedom of expression, privacy rights, the inviolability of human life, the protection of social peace, and the privileging of honest work over capital and manipulation. And there were protests against preferential treatment for foreigners.

The demands were clearly numerous. While some were more important in specific regions, all of them were spontaneous and reflected the general wishes of the society. They did not stem from any doctrine. The existence of many common problems explains the spread of citizen organizations—a phenomenon that only subsequently was interpreted in the light of specific theories or ideologies. Later, when the rigidity of government bodies suffocated the new social demands, they found fertile ground in numerous ideologies such as socialism, communalism, anarcho-syndicalism, democratic liberalism, the social Christian movement, Protestantism, and Catholicism.

Modern Industry and New Directions

The arrival in Mexico of new currents of thought being discussed in Europe and elsewhere in the Americas provided context for the public debate. Ships arriving at Mexican ports brought news of strikes and other struggles of stevedores, longshoremen, and other workers in Europe, Cuba, Venezuela, and the United States, as well as other places in Mexico. The Industrial Revolution introduced a new division of labor and a reorganization of the labor force in the new railroad, telegraph, textile, brewing, and metalworking industries. Now the affinities or connections among workers were based upon their positions within the segmented

labor force. Workers in a specific position had more in common with their fellow workers in similar work positions, whether in a generating plant, machine shop, or maintenance facility. Work was carried out in coordination with other industrial facilities in Mexico or even abroad. Each industrial facility and every industry has a role to play in an extensive, complex, and coordinated industrial division of labor. The primary nexus between an individual worker and organized labor was now his work position. The new mobility in work life and the affinity between workers despite different locations and industries helped those with common problems to come together. Workers in new specializations, such as mechanics, machinists, boilermakers, and drivers, communicated closely with their colleagues both inside and outside of the country, stimulating the organization of workers.

Despite the growing importance of modern industry and relations between workers in different industrial sectors, the rural areas, both new and old, continued to carry the most weight in the country. The new social vitality introduced additional tensions into the countryside. A new regionalism arose, which, as in the past, preserved some ethnic characteristics but also incorporated the current social demands.

Social or popular Catholicism was one of the principal interpreters of regional demands. After a long period of profound conservatism after the liberal revolution and an adjustment to its new relation with the State, the Church began to play a political role and diplomatic relations with the Vatican were reestablished. A commitment to social involvement arose within the Church itself, as a consequence of a new doctrine, proclaimed in the encyclical *Rerum Novarum*, that opposed lay liberalism. A similar process took place in other Latin American and European countries, where the new social doctrine gained strong acceptance among the local clergy, parish priests, and, in general, those of the Church faithful who witnessed the people's needs on a daily basis.

The engagement of the Church in the social question, especially the involvement of local clergy and lay Catholics, led to the creation of Catholic circles in old and new rural areas where cooperatives had been formed, sometimes with the support of landowners and the political elite. The Catholic movement was diverse and at times contradictory. New religious orders committed to more profound social engagement, like the Salesians and the Sisters of the Sacred Heart, were arriving in Mexico. For its part, a lay Catholic network was deeply involved in organizing around popular demands, first in Jalisco and the Bajío, and later in the entire country.

The Catholic renovation was expressed in Chiapas through Bishop Orozco, who sharpened the social action of the Church in 1902 by reinforcing the authority of the hierarchy and the clergy. Bishop Gillow did the same in Oaxaca. The so-called reconquest of Catholic souls spread rapidly in Indian areas, where the Church tried to destroy the unauthorized religious hierarchy that in the absence of clergy had given the religion a strong vernacular component.

The penetration of social Catholicism in the Mexican regions was simultaneous with the renewal of liberalism. The new liberalism stemmed from opposition to recent Church-State relations and to Porfirio Díaz's policy, beginning in 1890, of reconciliation and cooperation between state-based elites and government authorities and their counterparts on the federal level. This policy, which was discussed in chapter 8, created divisions both between the authorities and the population and within the government itself.

Díaz's policy of establishing special arrangements with the Church and with the traditional large social and economic interests led to a deep split between "official" liberalism, that is, the liberalism in power, and liberal constitutionalism. The latter took on a strong lay and anticlerical connotation and became the leading voice for the ideals of "the glorious Constitution of 1857," the guarantor of "the happiness of the peoples." This view advocated the strict enforcement of the constitution as the only sure way to provide order, the rule of law, and freedom.

Liberal constitutionalism, or democratic liberalism, began to spread slowly as a generation of liberals strongly criticized violations of the constitution in 1877-1879. Thanks to pressure from them during those years, Congress passed an electoral reform that opened the way for electoral circles to participate in organized political activity. Electoral clubs and political discussion groups spread the new ideas, which were then translated into concrete action in various political arenas. By 1896, liberal constitutionalism had a presence in practically every state in the republic with the exception of Oaxaca and was particularly strong in the northern states, the states of the central plateau, and on the Gulf Coast. Some data report as many as 113 formal circles of liberal constitutionalism around the country.

In addition to these liberal constitutionalist clubs, we would have to add social Catholic circles, Protestant schools, and other political and civic education clubs. None of these formations had any national structure, however; they were organized within municipalities or town centers. At times they counted on statewide links, but rarely interstate ones.

Unfortunately, there are no studies of these spontaneous forms of organization, nor of the public opinion, citizenship education, or daily political activities they would have represented. If we consider, however, that daily political events were discussed and decided at the municipal level, we can imagine that there may have been as many, or more, such circles as there were municipalities in the country.

The spread and influence of democratic liberals has been underestimated, and when they are mentioned, they tend to be linked to the elite or to the comfortable, educated urban middle class that repudiated the Díaz regime more for political than for social reasons. This is a false image. Among the new democratic liberals were people from other economic sectors and with worldviews that were not necessarily representative of the middle class.

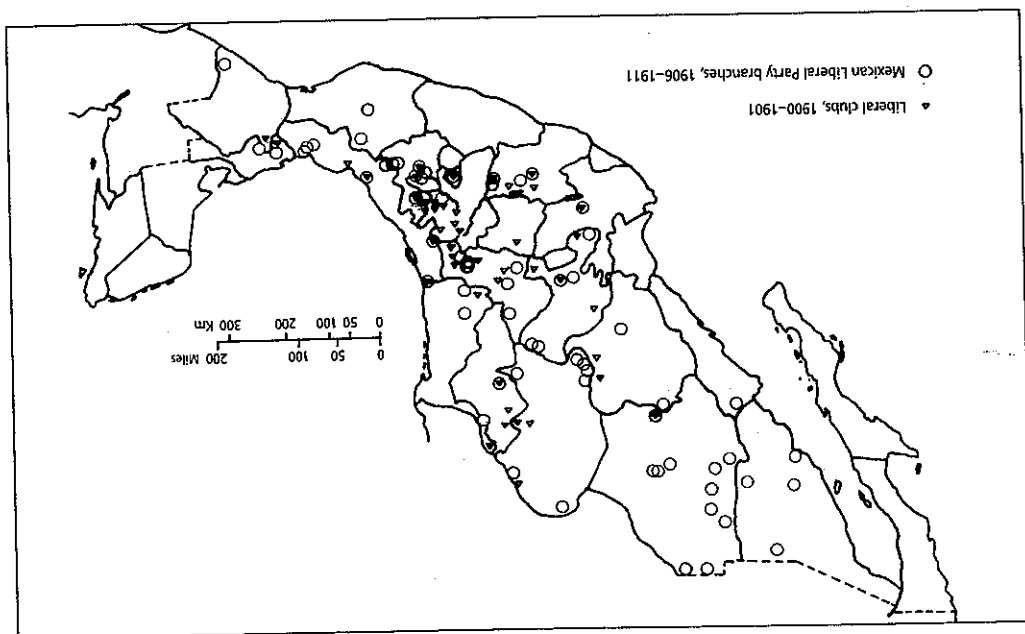
It is an exaggeration to say that democratic liberalism was a strictly urban phenomenon. The fact that democratic liberal clubs operated out of cities and towns does not mean that all their members lived there. It could be that clubs met in towns because that was where people who lived in villages and settlements went to do their business and shopping. In this sense, the diverse expressions of liberal constitutionalism reproduced the tradition, born of the liberal revolution, of bringing together people of different sectors and social classes.

New Demands

As the nineteenth century drew to a close, the new ideologies that filtered into Mexico were being picked up and reformulated within the social collectivity, influencing social and political groupings. By 1890, these culturally motivated reconstructions were producing changes in traditional organizations. The new ideologies permeated society from the municipalities to the political elites. Some groups referred to the historical liberal tradition, the 1857 Constitution, and the liberal republican revolution, others to Church social doctrine, and still others to anarchist, communalist, and socialist ideas.

As the twentieth century began, democratic liberals, Catholics, and socialists were forming organizations to oppose the government, but without any formal relations among them. Their opposition was not yet capable of influencing public opinion, so it constituted no real threat to the regime, and the government made no effort to restrict any of them other than the socialists and anarchists. After 1900, though, the strength of these networks became clear.

MAP 9.1. Distribution of liberal clubs and Mexican Liberal Party branches. (Source: François-Xavier Guerra, *México: Del Antiguo Régimen a la Revolución*, vol. 2 [Mexico City: Fondo de Cultura Económica, 1988], p. 18.)



As has been stated, liberal groups were demanding full compliance with the 1857 Constitution, and lay Catholics were appealing for a reordering of the social collectivity. At first, Catholic workers' circles competed and even clashed among themselves in the attempt to gain adherents. At the same time, the new liberals clashed with anarchists and socialists. In the first years of the new century, these divisions hardened, and more militant groups appeared calling for direct action. Working conditions had worsened by 1907, and, in a break from the previous decade, the demand for labor generally slackened outside the newest economic sectors of oil and textiles around the Gulf of Mexico, harbor construction in Veracruz, and the light and power infrastructure of Mexico City. The number of Mexicans living in the United States grew from less than 78,000 in 1900 to more than 250,000 in 1910.

The lack of work had its first impact on the rural labor market, where sharecroppers, renters, and seasonal workers lost access to land or found that the conditions of access had become more stringent. *Haciendas* erected walls in order to protect their harvests and water supplies, cutting off resources and reducing the mobility of villagers who farmed their own plots or raised livestock on communal grazing lands. Real wages decreased, and peasant servitude reverted to its harshest forms in the entire southeast.

The reduction in demand for labor, probably a part of the business cycle, struck hard at mining, transportation, and services, while construction was the sector least affected. The growth of employment in construction and energy provided work for younger workers, despite the drawbacks of more difficult working conditions and employment insecurity. Labor migration can be measured in the population growth of new towns and, beginning in 1900, the number of migrants to the United States.

All these circumstances, almost unknown until this time, changed the world of work and the human geography associated with it. In 1880, liberal legislation protected artisans, laborers, and skilled and semiskilled workers, enforcing their rights of freedom of association and free labor through individual contractual employment. By the beginning of the twentieth century, however, a new demand for social rights was being heard. This is understandable. Before, small business owners and tradespeople could still collaborate through *pueblo*-based guilds. They could found mutual-aid societies and cooperative assistance funds as compensatory mechanisms to redress economic disparities. Under the new circumstances posed by the modern division of labor, workers in the service,

TABLE 9.1. Population Distribution in Traditional and New Economic Sectors, 1900-1910

	1900		1910		Annual Rate of Growth (%)
	(Millions)	%	(Millions)	%	
Total population	13.60	—	15.10	—	1.1
Economically active population	5.24	—	5.71	—	0.9
Traditional Sector					
Agriculture	3.18	60.7	3.60	63.0	1.2
Manufacturing	0.61	11.6	0.60	10.5	-0.1
Mining	0.10	1.9	0.10	1.8	-0.1
Construction	0.06	1.1	0.08	1.4	1.7
Commerce	0.26	4.9	0.30	5.3	0.5
Services	0.83	15.9	0.40	14.0	-0.1
"New" Sector					
Fuel and energy	0.01	0.3	0.02	0.4	1.8
Transportation	0.06	1.1	0.06	1.0	-0.8
Technical and professional	0.13	2.5	0.15	2.6	0.6

SOURCES: *Estadísticas Económicas del Porfiriato* (Mexico City: El Colegio de México, 1916), pp. 38-60; Fernando Rosenzweig, *El Desarrollo Económico de México, 1800-1910* (Toluca: El Colegio Mexiquense, 1989), p. 236.

industrial, and technical sectors had yet to reorganize and find their points of leverage. New realities had to be considered. Unlike rural and artisanal labor, modern industrial and mining workers sell only their labor power. Consequently, the remuneration for labor performed is the worker's principal and almost sole means of subsistence. What is more, working conditions in the period we are discussing, universally described as hellish, were subject to no legislative supervision whatsoever, leaving the workers utterly unprotected.

The available data tell us that salaries stagnated between 1890 and 1900, increased by 12.6 percent between 1900 and 1907, and then fell 17.9 percent from 1907 to 1911, more than canceling the previous gain. This is a gross generalization, however, because in any newly industrializing country there are extreme wage differences across industries and even among different employers in a given city. The scanty data on working-class family budgets are not very helpful either, but one significant factor

is worth noting: about 70 or 75 percent of salaries was used for food, the purchase of corn alone accounting for over 20 percent of income.

The reality of deteriorating living conditions and the nascent workers movement, on the other hand, are statistically well attested. Between 1900 and 1905, there were twenty-nine strikes, but between 1906 and 1910, the number shot up to 106. Most probably the heightened organization of work had led to more modern and effective workers' organizations. In this sense, the number of strikes in the textile industry is important to note, since this was the most developed manufacturing sector. This industry was the object of 10 strikes between 1900 and 1905 (34 percent of the total strikes) and 77 between 1906 and 1910 (72 percent of a total 106). A similar pattern may have played out among railroad and energy-sector workers, but that information is not available.

It has often been presented as incontrovertible fact that 1906 saw a tremendous mobilization of textile workers in Río Blanco and Orizaba in the state of Veracruz, as well as in Puebla and Tlaxcala; of copper miners in Cananea, Sonora; and of mechanics on the main rail lines. They all protested low salaries, poor conditions, and the favoritism shown foreign workers. If we examine the strike cycle, however, it can be seen that the most intense activity was in fact in the textile sector. Of a total of eight strikes in the first half of 1906, five were in textiles. In the second half of the year, textiles accounted for seventeen out of nineteen strikes. In the first half of 1907, fourteen out of twenty were in the same industry. In all, there were twelve textile strikes in Puebla, sixteen in Veracruz, thirty-seven in Mexico City, one in Jalisco, two in Tlaxcala, three in Querétaro, and three in the state of Mexico. The qualitative importance of the miners' strike in Cananea, Sonora, is not to be underestimated, but the critical working-class mobilization was in the textile industry because of the number of workers it employed (some thirty-one thousand), its geographical dispersion in seven states, and its location in numerous urban centers, where strikes had a dramatic effect on social and economic life and on other social groups.

Textile workers in multiple factories acted together for the first time in the 1906-1907 movement. In December 1906, workers in thirty Puebla mills collaborated to defend their salaries and to demand a reduction in hours, regular Saturday payment, the standardization of fines for poorly executed work, the end of mistreatment by supervising master workers, no employment of children under fourteen, the right to a minimum pension, increased pay for the night shift, and the elimination of company stores, *tiendas de raya*, where workers were effectively paid in kind.

The workers also demanded respect for their political rights. In concrete terms this meant the recognition of the constitutional guarantees to free expression and freedom of association, and the employers' full respect for Article 13 of the 1857 Constitution, which asserted full equality before the law for all citizens, workers and industrialists alike, and prohibited the trial of any citizen by a special court. The workers' demands were not only social and economic but also political and institutional. They demanded social justice and political equality.

The Democracy Movement

The sixth reelection of Porfirio Díaz, in June and July of 1910, drove a wedge in society between the democratic anti-reelectionist movement and the conservative reelectionist movement. The anti-reelectionists were also demanding expanded political and economic prospects for the new generation of Mexicans, which were beyond the capacity of the existing system to provide. Within a few months, what had begun as a peaceful democracy movement became a national insurrection with the participation of large numbers of *hacendados* and entrepreneurs, opposition politicians, merchants, white-collar workers and professionals, ranch hands and administrators, miners, industrial workers, railroad employees, muleteers, cattle herders, and peasants, among others. An anti-reelectionist movement of such magnitude had until then seemed inconceivable. Porfirio Díaz was celebrating his eightieth birthday and had been reelected half a dozen times in his thirty-five years of power.

Francisco I. Madero belonged to one of the most prominent landowning and entrepreneurial families of northern Mexico. He had studied both in Europe and in the United States and was a strong advocate of progressivism. He began a nationwide campaign for the presidency in 1909 with the support of his powerful family group—an unusual step that enabled him to reach out to the general public. His basic constituency was the middle class, and his great innovation was to establish connections between worker and peasant demands and between social and political ones, crystallized in the calls for free town councils, the elimination of political bosses, effective suffrage, and no reelection. Madero was the beneficiary of a long tradition of political opposition in the northeast and in other regions of the country. Since 1892, this opposition had been kept alive through years of vicissitudes by liberal constitutionalists, Catholic modernizers, Protestant groups, anarcho-sindicalists, and followers of

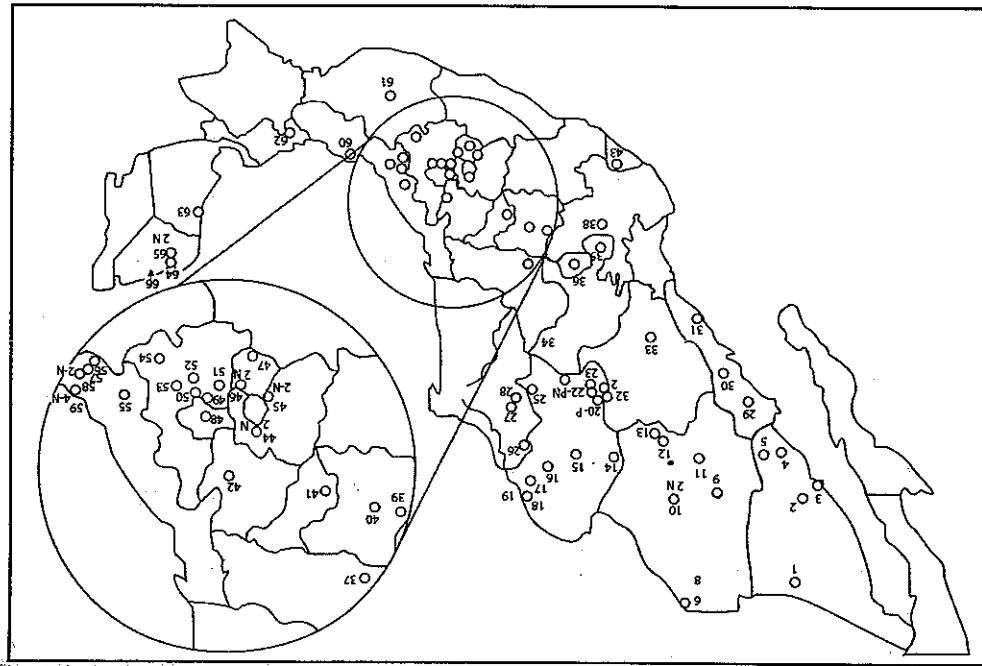
Ricardo Flores Magón and Bernardo Reyes. Throughout the country, the movement was coordinated and spread by organizations that sponsored congresses, tours, and conventions. The dimensions of the 1909–1911 anti-re-electionist movement would have been inconceivable without this history (see map 9.2).

Porfirio Díaz was well aware that the anti-re-electionist movement was a national force, and in June 1910, before the elections, he ordered Madero's arrest. Several uncertain weeks followed, but the elections produced a resounding victory for the government, and with the success of this fraud, the electoral route for political action was closed.

Through his Plan de San Luis, Madero called upon the nation to rise up in arms. The insurrectional plan—logical and seemingly feasible—called for the capture of several important state capitals, which was expected to attract the support of a significant nucleus of federal army officers. Operations would be coordinated by a revolutionary junta, and it was expected that other rebel circles would join the movement. The goal was for a handful of state capitals and railroad centers to fall into Maderista hands, which would put them in a position of strength from which to enter into negotiations with the government. But the government repressed the uprising, the Maderistas did not take any cities, and the insurrection took on new characteristics. The movement burst out of its initial organizational confines and into regions where the leadership and social composition of rebel circles fell to ranchers, small business owners, mulattoes, miners, white- and blue-collar workers, professionals, railway employees, *hacienda* administrators, and peasants in general. From December 1910 until the end of March 1911, rebel bands wreaked destruction on a daily basis, targeting bridges, railroads, telegraph lines, and small towns with only local defenses. The spontaneity and broad diffusion of the insurrection forced the government to employ its garrisons in defense of the principal cities, at the cost of mobility and flexibility. The insurrection was so effective and widespread that the political-military crisis of the Porfirista regime became unmanageable.

The government could not last more than a few months under these circumstances. Díaz publicly acknowledged his defeat and resigned in an attempt to salvage the regime. The two parties signed the Treaty of Cuernavaca in May 1911, which stipulated that in return for Díaz's resignation, the Maderistas would advance the electoral and political proposals they had advocated in 1909–1910.

The democratic insurrection, like any other, created and strengthened new organizations and promoted demands for social and political



MAP 9.2. The anti-re-electionist election campaign: anti-re-electionist clubs founded in 1909 and 1910. The points numbered 1–66 are places where there are records of anti-re-electionist clubs or, in the cases of Guadalupe and Mexico City, clubs affiliated with the Independent or the Democratic Nationalist parties, which aligned themselves with the National Anti-Re-election Party, endorsing its principles and candidates. In the cases of Chihuahua, Nuevo León, Zacatecas, Puebla, and Yucatán, the references are general in the sense that there were a great many clubs, but more detailed information is unavailable. A number followed by “N” indicates the number of clubs or similar groups in the indicated location; otherwise, there was just one club in that place. A numbered location followed by “P” indicates the probable site of a club. All locations are approximate. (Source: Santiago Portilla, *Una Sociedad en Armas* [Mexico City: El Colegio de México, 1995], p. 116.)

change. This process was accelerated by the fact that many of these organizations had also developed their military capacity by 1911. At its peak, the democratic insurrection mobilized sixty to eighty thousand armed combatants, many more than in the federal army.

The insurrection was a national phenomenon, although its intensity differed from region to region, and some areas were untouched by the conflict. The location of rebel activities coincided with the centers of political opposition in 1884, 1892, 1895, 1901, and 1906, illustrating the insurrection's continuity with the political past.

The leadership of the democratic movement headed by Francisco Madero was fundamentally a coordinating body for many strongly autonomous regional revolutionary organizations that all agreed upon one national goal: to liquidate the Porfiriato and transform the old social and political order. The result was the resounding defeat of the Porfiriato with the triumph of Madero in the election of October 1911. Held under the old system of single indirect elections by means of electors, Madero received 98 percent of the vote. In the vice presidential results, however, there was a notable split among the Maderistas and between Maderistas and Catholics. José María Pino Suárez, a moderate Maderista, received 53 percent of the vote, the conservative Francisco León de la Barra received 29 percent, and Vázquez Gómez, a more radical Maderista, received 17 percent. The democratic coalition and the conservative coalition were each supported by about half of the public.

With the introduction of universal male suffrage on May 22, 1912, the first democratic Congress was elected, as was a partially reconstituted Senate. It should be noted that the new electoral law not only promoted broad participation in voting for all male citizens but also recognized all parties and political groups with at least 150 members and guaranteed the broadest possible freedom of opinion and public expression to all parties and political circles.

The 1912 electoral campaign further mobilized the public opinion already engaged at the national level by the presidential election of 1911. It was a major opportunity to bring some coherence to the multitude of political demands being made by disparate groups. But we know little about this first democratic electoral process in Mexico—the campaign, how candidates were registered, how coalitions were formed. We do know that many candidates received votes—there were more than ten candidates in some districts. This tells us that there were multiple electoral options within the democratic and conservative blocs.

The essential fact is that in only five years, and especially between 1910

and 1912, society had taken a qualitative leap forward in political organization. The National Catholic Party participated in this first democratic election in Mexico, and its participation defined the electoral alliances: two large blocs formed to reflect the polarization of forces, the Conservative Bloc and the Liberal Renewal Bloc, which included the Progressive Constitutional Party of Gustavo Madero, the president's brother. The fluidity of political life in those years did not allow for categorical divisions, however. The liberal renewal bloc also included some members of the National Catholic Party, and some independent groups attempted to promote and capitalize upon the discontent of conservative urban sectors.

It is difficult to interpret the 1912 congressional election results. Some newspapers reported that 130 deputies were *gobiernistas*, supporters of the group in power. This would have given the Maderistas 50.9 percent of the seats in Congress. Another fifty deputies (29.6 percent) were in the opposition, and the remaining seventy-five (29.4 percent) identified themselves as independents. It appears that the elections provided a valuable opportunity to set a new direction for the country and were a corrective to the political fragmentation that resulted from the armed conflict. This is not an unusual phenomenon and had previously occurred in Mexico between 1867 and 1880. The electoral results spoke to a new democratic option in the form of coalition politics that pointed the country toward a new governability.

We attribute the crisis of the reform movement to the inability of the democratic elite to understand the speed and extent to which the armed insurrection had changed society and accelerated popular demands. The elite had attempted to overcome the political impasse from the top down. Gustavo Madero and the Progressive Constitutionalist Party intended to gain a majority in the Chamber of Deputies and to capture the open seats in the Senate, assuming that it would be possible to organize a new government by eliminating or quashing the conservative bench. The Maderista elite did not recognize that the election results clearly indicated a society divided three ways, and that no one of the three forces had the strength to dominate the political process. Concluding that with 51 percent of the deputies it did not need to work in a broader coalition, the government gave the conservatives the opportunity to reach an agreement with a not entirely conservative grouping, the Catholics. Together the conservatives and the Catholics held a majority of the seats in the Senate, though not in the Chamber of Deputies.

The reformers' control of the Chamber of Deputies under the leadership of Gustavo Madero and Luis Cabrera, a lawyer and staunch

Maderista, led to constant friction with the Senate. While the deputies seriously took up the need for policies to restore lands to the communities, conservative and Catholic senators concentrated on hobbling the government at every turn. The intolerance and inflexibility of both blocs produced a gridlock that extended to the highest levels of state authority, producing a growing power vacuum.

Under the circumstances, it was no surprise that the conservative forces appealed to the only well-organized state body, the federal army, to organize a coup. They failed twice. The first attempt was in October 1912, instigated by the Científicos and led by General Félix Díaz, nephew of the exiled president. The second was in February 1913, led by General Manuel Mondragón and Bernardo Reyes, former minister of war and organizer of the Second Reserve in 1902. They finally succeeded later that month, when a group of *Reyista* officers joined the conspiracy along with General Victoriano Huerta, a hard-liner with a strong following in the officer corps.

The violence of the military coup, the assassinations of the president and vice president, and the formation of a Catholic and conservative government led the democratic forces to organize in opposition. Some leaders of the Casa del Obrero Mundial, a radical workers' movement, began to circulate among existing revolutionary garrisons; others remained in Mexico City. The social Catholic movement distanced itself from the Catholic hierarchy and the illegitimate government. Most important, protests and rebellions against the takeover broke out in the states, especially in Sonora, Chihuahua, and Coahuila. Álvaro Obregón, a farmer, schoolteacher, and recently elected mayor, was given command of the militias in his state of Sonora; the figure of Francisco Villa emerged in Chihuahua; and the constitutionally elected governor Venustiano Carranza, twice elected mayor and an avowed anti-Porfirian and anti-reactionist, headed up in the resistance in Coahuila.

The Plan de Guadalupe of March 27, 1913, is considered the foundation of the constitutional movement, but insufficient attention has been paid to the fact that with the assassination of the constitutionally elected President Madero and his vice president, the federal compact was ruptured for the first time in Mexican history, in the sense that sovereign state authorities determined the federal government to be illegitimate and unconstitutional. History vindicates the durability of Mexican federalism, for when the federal compact was broken, a constitutionalist movement arose to return sovereignty to the states. Both the constitutionalists and then Emiliano Zapata, a village authority from southern

Morelos, expressed this idea. Zapata's manifesto of March 4, 1913, included these words: "With the victory of the Felicista [led by Félix Díaz] uprising, a spurious and illegitimate government holds power . . . [one] which can never represent our national sovereignty, nor that of the states, in accordance with the 1857 Constitution." The Plan de Ayala was reformulated on May 30, 1913, to characterize Victoriano Huerta as "a usurper of authority."

While in 1910 Madero had appealed to the army to join his movement, Carranza in 1913 had used his position as governor of Coahuila to decree, along with the legislature, the rupture of the federal compact, the withdrawal of recognition from the federal army, and the recognition of the Constitutional Army as the only legitimate military force. No doubt the recentness of the state elections had facilitated this process. Officeholders had just taken up their positions, and a significant number of anti-reactionists had won municipal posts. They proceeded to integrate Maderista rebel groups into the irregular forces of their states.

The 1913-1914 *pronunciamientos* against the Huerta dictatorship closely paralleled the map of the highly regional 1911 insurgency. A strong northern center radiated toward Coahuila, Durango, and Zacatecas; the states of Morelos and Guerrero formed the core of a central zone; a moderately strong zone ran through the north-central states of San Luis Potosí and Tamaulipas; and, in Sonora, Álvaro Obregón headed the state militia. Once again there was only a weak presence in the far south.

While the 1911 power shifts and organizational changes had primarily been accomplished by political means, the corresponding events in 1913-1914 were the result of military action. As a result, society was ever more militarized—a phenomenon that paralleled the growth of the federal army, which Victoriano Huerta tried to increase to a force of 200,000 troops.

The Huerta regime collapsed after fifteen months of being in power, from March 1913 to August 1914. The federal army was defeated not in large-scale battles but in a war that resembled the events of 1911, including surprise attacks and the frequent defection of garrisons. The army was hampered by its own slowness, lack of logistical support, and lack of trust among its officers and between them and the population. Widespread demoralization led to the army's surrender and dissolution. The military institution's disappearance from the scene left the country in the hands of the victorious political-military factions and provided an unusual opportunity for political reorganization on a national scale. Within Latin America this disbanding of a regular army is unique to Mexico and accounts

for the stable evolution of the country's political system. The armed forces that fought in the conflicts of 1914 to 1920 were civilians in arms upholding the tradition of the National Guard. A professional modern army was developed only as of the 1950s, once a civilian political framework had been set in place.

From 1914 onward, peace was one of the most important demands of the citizenry. All agreed on one thing: without peace, other demands could not be satisfied. Without peace and stability there was no possibility of national reconstruction or renewal, and only peace could bring the local and regional pieces of the national mosaic back together.

The Revolutionary Groups

Unlike in 1911, political groups in 1914 tried to respond to the demand for peace, knowing that if it were not reestablished, social and political reforms would not be realized and the revolutionary struggle would have been for naught. Each demand received a different response from the various revolutionary groups, according to their strength, the territorial control they exercised, the relationship between their urban and rural components, and their own interests. The Constitutional Army, headed by Venustiano Carranza, represented a segment of society that came to hold governorships and mayoralties as a result of the revolution. The positions of these men as military commanders deepened their control over the regions, enabling them to secure most of the available business contracts. The Carrancistas, for example, occupied strategic zones and benefited from an effective political-military and administrative apparatus. Venustiano Carranza, as Primer Jefe of a movement that favored an immediate return to constitutional order, developed a centralized political leadership with a fairly powerful civilian component more disposed to restoring order than negotiating with popular sectors. Constitutionalist cohesion did not mean complete unity for at least one of its factions, however, that of Álvaro Obregón. While Obregón's forces depended on Carranza for supply, they tended to assert a certain autonomy when it came to military policy. This was partly because they were cut off from their territorial base in Sonora and needed to form alliances with the lower- and middle-class population sectors of the areas they occupied.

The followers of Francisco Villa were markedly heterogeneous, both socially and politically. Villa's Division of the North was composed of ranch hands; muleteers; agricultural, mining, and railroad workers; and

former soldiers of the Porfirian army. Its higher officers included federal army deserters, Catholic Maderistas, and former ranch foremen and supervisors. The relationship of the officer corps with social Catholics, Protestants, and former federals provided a means for Villismo to build bridges to people in other states and even internationally. The funds necessary to maintain the division were raised from confiscated *haciendas* and from compulsory taxes levied on commercial agriculture. The operation was administered from a headquarters in Chihuahua that provisioned both the Division of the North and the needy among the population. Villa's agrarian program of 1915 proposed to distribute land to veterans, widows, and orphans when hostilities ended.

In 1914–1915, Zapatismo represented the interests of the municipalities and *pueblos* with strong communitarian traditions based on the defense of their historical right to manage both private and collective patrimony over water, forests, pasture, and cropland. To these ends, the movement relied upon an extensive network of local notables and organic leaders who personified the long-standing defense of the right to self-government and municipal autonomy. In this sense, Zapatismo was more than a regional movement. By taking up the demands for self-government and municipal autonomy that resonated throughout the country, it came to extend its influence over *pueblos* and municipalities in other regions.

Would three large social sectors with apparently incompatible bases and interests be able to find a way to live and work together to define a direction for the nascent State? The first effort in this regard was an attempt to reach unity among the constitutionalists gathered in Mexico City on October 1, 1914; this meeting led to a new recognition of the Primer Jefe, Carranza. In addition, all the revolutionary groups agreed to meet at a convention in Aguascalientes on October 10, 1914. The differences among the armed factions represented there were a reflection of the general social upheaval taking place. Constitutionalism itself was by no means homogeneous. Obregón, for example, was disposed to advance worker-peasant social organization and to develop the growing call of the middle classes for greater political and economic rights. The Villistas and Zapatistas, inclined to advance the social movement by producing tangible gains in the areas of social rights and land reform, seemed to be potential allies of Obregón. The most strictly constitutionalist grouping, centered around the forces of Carranza, was convinced that the key to peace would be reforms to the 1857 Constitution in order to reliably and unambiguously codify newly won social and political rights. Carranza be-

lieved that in the absence of the legal instruments necessary to guarantee a state of law, pressure from the popular movement would lead to a long civil war.

The differences and deep hostility between the different factional leaders ended up producing a wider split. The constitutionalist faction pulled out, and the convention selected Francisco Villa as military chief. When the forces under Villa's command entered Mexico City in December 1914, they obliged the constitutionalists to withdraw to their stronghold in Veracruz, where they reaffirmed the authority of the provisional government under Carranza. The convention delegates had not been able to reach any major agreements, and as a result the conventionist government lost the support of Villa and with it the authority to enforce its will. The provisional president of the convention, Eulalio Gutiérrez, and other former delegates deplored Villista outrages, saying that homes had been violated daily and the right to life and property had been violated, sowing fear and apprehension in Mexican society. Gutiérrez declared the limits of the revolution: "We cannot conceive of it in an alliance with theft and murder. . . . It must be remembered that Mexico has struggled not just for bread, but also for freedom, for a government that respects and guarantees the rights of all against whomever may violate them, and a system of law that applies equally to all and is the firm basis of our progress and well-being."

The relative power and momentum among the various factions began to shift in September 1915. The Villistas were defeated in the Bajío region and failed in a campaign to take the petroleum-rich area around Tampico, forcing them to retreat to their old base in Chihuahua. The constitutionalists turned back Zapatista forays into Guerrero and Puebla, and the latter retreated to their own territory in Morelos. The United States' recognition of the Carranza government in October 1915 established the definitive claim of power by the constitutionalists. From this moment on, Carranza exercised extraordinary powers as *Primer Jefe*, acting upon the widespread desire for order and for work. He attempted to establish a central bank, promoted the normalization of agricultural property, and sought to devise mechanisms for the resolution of disputes between workers and employers. With the eventual victory of the movement, he intended to explicitly incorporate the reforms brought to bear by his provisional government into the constitution.

One goal of Carranza's provisional government was to curtail food riots and protests against the devaluation of paper money, which enriched speculators and further impoverished the poor. Carranza's preconstitu-

tional government from 1915 to 1917 coincided with increased exports because of the world war. The government used the proceeds from the export of strategic goods and food staples to stabilize regions falling under its control and to generate income. It operated in a strongly statist fashion that included military control of the railroads, regulation of business and of grain production, and the seizure of banks.

Carranza and constitutionalism had gained so much power that the Obregonistas, Villistas, and Zapatistas intensified their collaboration in an effort to counter them. When Obregón occupied Mexico City in March 1915, his improved ties with the Casa del Obrero Mundial led to an agreement in which its leadership made a commitment to organize the workers throughout the constitutionalist-occupied area. In return, the Red Battalions were formed to operate on various fronts. Carranza and the most conservative constitutionalists thought that the agreement was but a maneuver by Obregón to increase his personal power. But Obregón's policy of forming coalitions with popular sectors led him to hand over management of the telephone and telegraph company to the workers. This seems to have been the beginning of Obregón's relationship with the working-class leader Luis N. Morones. In 1918, the two men would sign a secret mutual assistance pact, and Morones would later help Obregón reach the presidency.

Relations between the workers' movement and the Zapatistas solidified when the conventionist government came under Zapatista control between July 1914 and May 1915. During the Zapatista administration, Mexico City was more orderly than ever before, partly due to the cooperation between Zapatistas and workers, which put an end to strike movements. In addition, the Federal District's judiciary was reestablished and the free circulation of all the currencies distributed by the revolutionary factions was accepted, so that the flow of goods was unimpeded. They reconciled with the Church, in particular with the new vicar general, Pedro Benavides. Collaboration between Zapatistas and workers led to the founding in those months of the Sindicato Mexicano de Electricistas, the Mexican Electricians Union, an organization whose members seem to have collaborated with the Zapatista city administration. When the convention moved its government to Morelos, south of Mexico City, the original Zapatista project was enhanced, as the provisional government took on a formal structure that included the Executive Council of the Mexican Republic, with a president and a governing council.

Zapatismo spread beyond Morelos; in the April 1916 Manifesto to the Nation, signed by the civilian representatives of thirty-eight generals of

different regions, it was agreed that a parliamentary republic would be established (Article 33), municipal autonomy would be recognized (Article 32), and the Senate, considered an aristocratic and conservative body, would be eliminated. Congress would be unicameral (Articles 34 and 35), and the judiciary would be autonomous and independent (Article 36). All of the above was in accordance with the Plan de Ayala and the revolution's program of social and political reforms.

Social groups outside the ranks of constitutionalism, including significant anarchist forces, supported and joined the process of social and political organization. The provisional executive council in Morelos legislated the establishment of small-property rights at the expense of the rich sugar-producing *haciendas*; the direct vote and no reelection; municipal autonomy, including a municipal judiciary and municipal cooperatives for agricultural and industrial producers; the right to work, with guarantees for the freedom of association, the right to strike, and the right to engage in boycotts; unemployment insurance; an eight-hour workday; salaries indexed to the regional cost of living; the abolition of scrip and payment in kind through company stores; and the right to free enterprise by means of antimonopoly legislation and regulated expropriation in the name of the public good. Taxes were made equitable through the imposition of a progressive tax regime and the elimination of consumption taxes.

The Birth of a New Order

Carranza mobilized rapidly in mid-1916, alarmed by popular support for the new coalition and the possible defection of constitutionalist generals, particularly Obregón. Ten days after the Carrancistas occupied Mexico City, the city's workers launched the offensive that they had promised the Zapatistas. The United Federation of the Federal District called a general strike, and the electricians took the lead in bringing it to bear. Carranza immediately decreed the death penalty for strikers and jailed their leadership.

Obregón made no decisive move but threatened to resign from the Secretariat of War. Carranza forced him to choose between staying at the head of the secretariat or going to Spain, and he agreed to stay on, but with the proviso that after the elections he would step down and return to Sonora. Thus Carranza managed to neutralize the one general with the greatest potential to solidify the emerging coalition. At the same

time, he understood that the strikes were one aspect of a more general political plan, and he launched a two-part offensive. On the military front, he set fire to the harvests and concentrated civilians in hamlets in order to cut off popular aid to the Zapatistas. Politically, he attacked the autonomy of the *pueblos* of Morelos. In addition, he established the Constitutional Railroad System and put its workers under military discipline, and he dissolved the Casa del Obrero Mundial and ordered the arrest of all "agitators."

The rapid response to the nascent anti-Carranza coalition owed a lot to the nature of constitutionalism as the embryo of a new State. Although the divisions of the Constitutional Army enjoyed significant autonomy, the Primer Jefe was in a position to coordinate their activities. This applied to the Sonoran army of Álvaro Obregón, to Francisco Villa's Northern Division, and to the Army of the East, commanded by Carranza's nephew Pablo González. But the role of the Primer Jefe went beyond coordination. At the beginning of 1915, Carranza was in a position not only to coordinate but also to act as administrative, political, and military chief of all the main components of the Constitutional Army.

The ever more centralized organization of the Constitutional Army was due in a large part to the ability of Luis Cabrera, who was in charge of finances, to consolidate control over key cities and to dominate the periphery of the country in order to administer sea and land customs. Since the provisional government was based in Veracruz, two-thirds of all import income was within its immediate grasp. The strategy for the other third was simple and easy: maintain strategic control over transportation through the Constitutional Railroad System under military command, and free up forces from the occupation and administration of the interior in order to capture the Pacific and Gulf ports and the areas along the United States-Mexican border. The duties collected would generate hard currency and would provide hard cash to pay the army and the civil administration and keep the constitutionalist territories supplied.

Without sacrificing its regional bases, the Constitutional Army established a general command in the person of the Primer Jefe, and being a citizen army, it was able to project both its military and administrative policies on a national level. Its organizational complexity was greater than that of the Zapatistas. In order to maintain military mobility, it managed to name civil authorities and establish governmental functions in its territories very quickly. The immediate establishment of civil administration prevented the militarization of social and political demands or their subordination to military needs. The evidence tells us that the

constitutionalists' application of social and political reforms kept pace with their military defeats of the dictatorship. One example is the March 4, 1913, executive law on land distribution. It proclaimed "the urgent need to solve the agrarian problem, the distribution of lands, that is, through the expropriation of rural and urban properties of the Porfiristas and of Huerta's henchmen." The same law established that all inhabitants had the right "to gather in every small or large town and name their leader."

The December 1914 reformulation of the Plan de Guadalupe points in the same direction. The reformed plan exemplified the civil side of constitutionalism, which picked up the demands of the 1911-1915 period and set out to satisfy them through government action. Equality was construed as more than just formal "equality before the law" and integrated broader social components. Thus agrarian laws were instituted, as were laws against the monopolization of natural resources and laws to guarantee the social rights of all workers. Equality meant the direct vote and the strengthening of freedom of expression, freedom of opinion, freedom of the press, and freedom of association. The interesting thing about the reformulated Plan de Guadalupe is that it laid the basis for all the manifestos and plans that came after 1915.

The specific challenge for constitutionalism at the beginning of 1916 was to consolidate its victory over its principal armed adversaries so it could devote maximal energy and resources to governing the country. Ending the civil war was an urgent matter. The constitutionalist military was given *carte blanche*, while Carranza and the central bodies of the government concentrated on setting a viable political direction, responding to a minimal number of popular demands, and liquidating the anti-Carranza coalition that was coming together between 1914 and 1916.

The Economic Effort

The country had gone through economic difficulties from 1907 until the First World War, when wartime demand for agricultural products, minerals, oil, cotton, and other products skyrocketed. Before the war, the extraction of copper, gold, and especially silver had decreased. The 2,663 tons of silver produced in 1910 had dropped to 785 tons by 1915, which is to say that almost 70 percent of capacity was nonproductive. Harvests of commercial crops like sugar and cotton had dropped to 50 percent of capacity. Basic food crops like corn and wheat fared somewhat better, per-

haps due to the increased cultivation of marginal lands. Production levels did not drop for petroleum or for henequen because Yucatán saw little military activity during the revolution.

The decreased production was reflected in the level of international trade. Between 1910 and 1915, exports were stagnant at about 140 million dollars, and imports remained at about 90 million dollars. However, these stable dollar values reflected not the quantity of goods traded, but increased prices on international markets leading up to and during the First World War.

The economic indicators cited above are so general that they obscure the important fact that the 1911-1916 war seriously damaged the domestic transportation system, particularly the railroads. According to the Secretariat of War, national transport capacity as measured in rolling stock decreased almost 60 percent. The breakdown of the railroad system devastated the patterns of domestic commerce that had gradually developed in the last third of the nineteenth century, and trade reverted to regional markets. Since 74 percent of the freight stock connecting the north and the center of the country was out of circulation, it became more practical to export northern agricultural products to the United States than to sell them domestically.

Production and marketing were now regional or local, and since military commanders enjoyed considerable autonomy, they were able to appropriate resources in their zones to finance the war, and sometimes for personal enrichment. The insecurity and arbitrariness of economic life was another burden for the citizenry. Newly formed regulatory bodies were unable to protect the citizens adequately. Insecurity, famine, and disease were serious new problems that helped radicalize the various armed movements.

In addition to the degradation of transportation and communication, 1913 saw the destruction of the monetary system as each of the armed movements issued paper money and required its use in the area it occupied in order to raise funds for the war. By November 1914, the constitutionalists had issued almost 50 billion pesos. The Villistas issued their own paper money and required businesses in their zone to accept it. Many counterfeit bills circulated as well. It must be said that the Zapatas printed less paper money and opted instead to pay their bills in highly valued hard pesos. All together, the various groups must have issued the startling sum of 1.5 billion pesos in paper money.

The result of the uncontrolled printing of money was rapid currency depreciation. The 150 million pesos in circulation in 1912 had been mul-

multiplied by a factor of 10. A people accustomed to the use of coinage and convertible banknotes was forced to accommodate overnight to the use of overabundant paper money whose value could hardly, if at all, be guaranteed. Silver and gold coins disappeared from circulation, but the new bills were rejected by working-class wage earners. Their unease can be understood if we note that bills issued at par by Carranza in April 1913 had lost 30 percent of their value that December, 50 percent by August 1914, and 90 percent by the end of the year.

The monetary situation accelerated inflation in the price of basic goods, affecting economic life in general, especially in the cities, where all transactions, including salaries and wages, were in paper money. The urban poor and workers were undoubtedly the most affected. In addition to unemployment due to decreased production, they suffered great economic difficulties because they had no option but to use paper money to address all their basic needs.

Economic recovery was at first the result of an international event, the outbreak of the First World War. Exports took off beginning in 1916, and they had nearly doubled in value by 1920, from 242 to 426 million dollars. Imports began to increase in 1917, and they too had increased dramatically by 1920, growing in value from 105 to 180 million dollars. Growth was rapid in the mining sector, in commercial agriculture, and in internal consumption. The warring countries favored neutral Latin American countries like Mexico as suppliers of raw materials and agricultural goods. The international situation benefited the Mexican economy in two ways: the increased demand not only raised prices on export commodities but stimulated increased production. This made it possible to recover unused capacity.

Petroleum production jumped from 3.6 to 32.9 million barrels between 1911 and 1918. Pumping was restricted to certain geographical areas, which were guarded and defended by the oil companies. Owners of petroleum-rich properties received royalties from the petroleum companies and actively participated in the armed defense of their land. Most importantly to the security of petroleum operations, however, no political-military group wanted to kill the goose that laid the golden egg, since petroleum companies regularly paid all required export royalties. The data for 1921 tell us that, compared with the same results for 1910, the gross domestic product (measured at 1960 prices) was 7.6 percent higher, the mining and petroleum sector had increased 181 percent, and cattle ranching had increased 5.8 percent. The agricultural sector, internal commerce, and manufacturing, on the other hand, did not recover their 1910 levels until 1921.

The international situation provided incentive for national reconstruction, which in its way created a contradiction within liberalism due to the then-current statist tendencies. A new current of thinking arose among government ranks as officials proposed the implementation of some new social programs without abandoning their basic liberal orientation. Perhaps the world war could be exploited to reactivate the economy, stimulate investment, and address social needs. The new political-economic approach was to contain imports by increasing import duties, thus hopefully benefiting Mexican industry, which, according to John Womack, "[had] emerged intact from the struggle; it was not destroyed."¹ What hampered industry however, was the difficult problem of distribution in light of the degraded transportation system and the monetary collapse. Nationalization of the railroad and currency controls benefited manufacturing, especially beginning in 1917, and contributed to its recovery as well as to the expansion of consumer-oriented manufacturing and medium-scale industry.

The protectionist customs regime provided a powerful stimulus to the recovery. Beginning in 1916, customs duties were again paid in gold and silver. Salaries, too, were paid in coins or their equivalent in paper money according to the daily exchange rate. These measures made it possible to collect all taxes in coin or its equivalent in paper currency. The next step was to reestablish parity between paper money and gold coins, and finally, to regularize the payment of taxes in the paper money equivalent of gold. The government's rejection of unbacked paper money brought about a definitive return to the gold standard, in particular after January 1, 1917, when all salaries were to be paid either in Mexican gold coins or their equivalent value in silver coins.

The return to stability was no small matter, considering that monetary inflation had stirred up tremendous popular discontent and precipitated widespread urban protests. The government's success certainly generated a wider consensus in its favor.

The government's neoconservative policies limited social and political participation. Nevertheless, it would be a mistake to see the Constitutionalist Army as an army of occupation outside of Morelos, Oaxaca, Chiapas, and perhaps Yucatán and Tabasco. In the areas where local politicians and Carrancista military commanders could work together, the

1. See John Womack Jr., "The Mexican Revolution 1910-1920," in Leslie Bethell, ed., *The Cambridge History of Latin America* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984), vol. 5, pp. 79-154.

Constitutionalist Army promoted the renewal of political life. At first, this renovation was influenced by "northern ideas," but when over one hundred thousand soldiers were mobilized and sent outside their own regions, they intermingled with and were exposed to the experiences of others from all around the country. We should remember that in 1915, the government depended on the Constitutionalist Army to govern the many states where it was the only authoritative presence. It was also the principal body to which the middle and upper social groups within pacified areas could address their needs.

Without a doubt, northern military commanders and troops were present in the center and south of the country. Many of them arbitrarily appropriated goods to themselves or operated personal businesses with the benefit of their military authority. Their negative practices were more spectacular than their positive ones, though, and tend to obscure the cooperation between the Constitutionalist Army and some civilians. They cooperated on the reestablishment of order through joint action against guerrillas and on the reactivation of municipal politics, in keeping with Carranza's December 15, 1915, decree that municipal governments should be chosen by direct popular election.

The 1916 municipal elections returned local government to civilians, an important step in the reestablishment of institutional order. Once again, as in 1812—although over one hundred years had passed and the historical circumstances were new—the municipal election process contributed to the reestablishment of order and of local institutions. The municipality reemerged showing new strengths. The electoral process brought about a new correlation of local forces with the Constitutionalist Army. Political clubs and electoral groupings were reconstituted and even strengthened through new organizations such as labor unions; farmers', peasants', and renters' leagues; and urban tenant associations. Between 10 and 30 percent of enrolled voters participated in the municipal elections of 1916, an impressive number given the state of war. Yet the process was not free of irregularities. As a result of political and military fragmentation and factionalism, the election was manipulated to put civilian allies of the Carrancistas in positions of power. Nevertheless, it marked the return of civilians to political life as rule by military decree yielded to the decisions of civilian bodies.

Carranza's intent to return confiscated property should be seen as part of his strategy to reorganize the country by handing properties back to their lawful owners. He transferred the land that had been confiscated from Porfiristas, Huertistas, and Convencionistas to a federal agency.

This centralized their management and generated additional government revenue. Thanks to this decision, Church real estate, which by itself represented 90 percent of all that had been confiscated in Puebla, was never returned. The State also retained the properties confiscated from Convencionistas and Huertistas. In some regions and localities, however, the return of confiscated property to its previous owners was not universal. Some governors redistributed land to needy peasants and returned *haciendas* and other lands only if they were abandoned or if their evacuation by the Constitutionalist Army would have caused new problems.

The policy on property restitution was somewhat balanced by the distribution of land to peasants and by bringing day laborers into the cash economy. Although the amount of land distributed was insignificant—only 180,000 hectares distributed to 48,000 families in 190 pueblos between 1915 and 1920—significant expectations were created when the government enforced labor laws and demanded that rural day laborers be paid in cash. More importantly, *hacienda*-based company stores—the use of which amounted to payment in kind—were abolished. Together with the mandate to pay workers in cash, this benefited the entire rural population and began to erode the institutions that had maintained peasant servility, which was especially strong in the south-central states.

As can be seen, national reconstruction was multifaceted, having social, economic, and political dimensions. It was not a unidirectional, top-down process, but one in which a plurality of actors were set in motion. If we reflect for a moment on these social actors, we can discern similarities with those of 1892, 1895, 1901, 1906–1907, and 1909–1910. The difference is that in 1911–1920, as in the mid-nineteenth century, the primary dynamic was toward the consolidation of a new relation between the elites and the wider population. This was the outstanding characteristic of the revolutionary period. The 1915–1920 postwar social process does not seem to have been regressive, a "betrayal of the revolution," or a rejection of new social demands.

The 1917 Constitution and the Return to Legality

In 1914, Carranza decreed an important reform of the 1857 Constitution, granting autonomy to municipal governments, accompanied by their return to civilians. These directives were reinforced when he declared, in 1915, the need to convert the reforms decreed during the revolutionary struggle into constitutional principles. The reforms were to be institu-

tionalized and incorporated into a new legal order guaranteed by a new federal constitution.

The delegates to the 1917 Constitutional Assembly carried out that task. Without abandoning the 1857 paradigm, they clarified and codified the fundamental meanings of the revolution in a new constitution. Politically, they reaffirmed the federalist State, its constitutional guarantees, and its separation from the Church. They developed political rights in the form of direct suffrage for all males. They gave form to the repeated social demands of society before and during the revolution for universal rights, the right to land, and the protection of the most vulnerable economic groups. The greatest contribution of Carranza and his constitutionalist followers was to give the country a legal instrument that provided for the rule of law, a progressive liberal-democratic constitution intended to apply the terms of the new liberalism to the reality of Mexican society.

In stating that the content of the new constitution was liberal-democratic, I am departing from previous interpretations in which the document has been called radical or pseudo-socialist on the basis of socioeconomic reforms introduced in Articles 27 and 123. Article 27 granted the nation the exclusive right of eminent domain, which provides for the expropriation of private property in the public interest. It also reserved underground mineral rights to the nation and authorized the government to grant mineral extraction contracts to individuals and to Mexican and foreign corporations duly constituted under Mexican law. Article 123 established the norms under which complex legislation would be passed that abolished debt peonage; regulated labor contracts, working conditions, and women's and children's labor; and established a minimum wage, an eight-hour workday, and the right to strike and to arbitration in disputes between labor and capital.

These two articles formally articulated the demands that had been made throughout two decades of social unrest. They provided the legal instruments to guide social, political, and economic progress. The federalism of the 1917 Constitution was much more than a mere carry over from that of 1857. It was a conceptual reformulation of the Mexican United States on the basis of a cooperative federalism. The constitution regulated the cooperation of the states in land distribution and labor law, but the application of the laws was the responsibility of each state. Article 115 guaranteed the political and economic autonomy of municipalities for the first time, thus affirming citizen rights. These rights were additionally reinforced at the political level by the direct vote and by requirements in

Article 3 for the provision of obligatory education, seen as necessary for establishing a real connection between political and social guarantees. A new balance between the executive and legislative branches was achieved. As memory of the parliamentary republic faded and disappeared, executive power was reinforced and the presidential republic was born.

If we are to be consistent and thus assess the revolutionary process in the light of historical evidence, we can say that the social norms enshrined in the 1917 Constitution are best evaluated in conjunction with the new freedom they guaranteed. In this sense, this constitution was more than a reform; it was a departure from the Constitution of 1857 to the extent that the union it established was not merely liberal but liberal-democratic. This constitution was the logical product of a process that began as a liberal revolution and became liberal-democratic along the way.

An appreciation of the 1917 Constitution helps us to understand how the governability it made possible led to an unprecedented equilibrium between the people and the elite. Without this understanding, we would be unable to interpret the post-1920 course of Mexican social and political history.